Q+A

Trouble In Paradise

Kajol plays a mother torn between an armyman husband and a radicalised son in the Kashmir-set JioHotstar movie *Sarzameen*, which releases on July 25



Q. In *Sarzameen*, you have worked with two newcomers—one behind the camera (Kayoze Irani) and one in front (Ibrahim Ali Khan). What was the energy on set like?

Ibrahim is on the quieter side. He was into the character, given it is intense. I loved how Kayoze commanded the ship. We had long conversations about what the film should be saying and the subtext of its scenes.

Q. Do you think newcomers now have it easier than you did when you made your debut in 1992?

I think it is easier for this generation, at least in the beginning. We were just thrown into the water, so it was sink or swim. That I feel is our strong point. Now, they have months of preparation—be it a dialogue coach or personal trainer or stylist, what to say or not to say.

Q. You return to the Dharma banner after a decade. *Sarzameen* must have been compelling.

It was really the script. I loved that it's an emotional film about three people who are thrown into different circumstances and how they all have to grow and adapt. Working on a Dharma film is very comfortable. On the first day, everyone was like, "Welcome back, Ma'am."

Q. Three decades and still going strong. What's your magic potion? How have you adapted to the changing industry?

You have to sip the potion slowly, and give it time to digest before taking the second sip. I've done selective work. I don't put unnecessary pressure on myself. I am OK not having a release every six months.

—with Suhani Singh

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